POST-COLONIAL THEATRE

Post-Colonial Nigerian Theatre

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

The plays and playwrights of independence and after: Soyinka, Rotimi, Sofola, Osofisan and the argument about what a Nigerian theatre should be.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- independence
- Soyinka
- Rotimi
- Sofola
- Osofisan

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A theatre for a new nation

At independence the question was not whether Nigeria would have a theatre but what kind. The universities, the arts councils and the new television service all wanted a national drama, and the plays of the 1960s argued about whether it should be built from European models, from Yoruba festival forms, or from both at once.

Wole Soyinka's A Dance of the Forests, written for the independence celebrations of 1960, answered with a festival play that refused to celebrate: it summoned the dead to judge the living. The argument has continued ever since.

Soyinka and total theatre

Soyinka's theatre is total: drum, dance, mask, song, mime and verse in one event, with a metaphysics drawn from Yoruba religion. The Lion and the Jewel (1959) is a comedy of the village and the modern; The Road (1965) is a nightmare of the lorry park; Death and the King's Horseman (1975) is a tragedy of colonial interference, drawn from a real incident in Oyo.

His criticism matters as much as his plays: Myth, Literature and the African World (1976) sets out the "fourth stage" and the argument that African drama must be understood in its own metaphysical terms.

Rotimi, Sofola, Osofisan

Ola Rotimi took the Greek tragedy and rebuilt it in Yoruba terms: The Gods Are Not to Blame (1968) is Oedipus in a Yoruba village, and Kurunmi (1969) is a history play about the collapse of an empire. His theatre is popular in the best sense - large, musical, direct.

Zulu Sofola was the first Nigerian woman to publish a major play, and Wedlock of the Gods (1972) is a tragedy of widowhood and custom that puts a woman's choice at the centre of the stage. Her later work turned to festival form and to the education of a generation of students at Ilorin.

Femi Osofisan came after them with a theatre of argument: Once Upon Four Robbers (1980), Morountodun (1982) and a body of criticism that attacked the mythic theatre of Soyinka as a politics of resignation. His plays use song, direct address and a chorus to make the audience think about power.

What the period left

The post-colonial decades produced a repertory that is still the backbone of Nigerian theatre: history plays, festival plays, satire, domestic tragedy and the musical. They also produced the institutions - the university departments, the National Theatre, the festivals - that a playwright now writes for or against.

The argument between myth and politics, ritual and revolution, is not settled. It is the live question of Nigerian dramatic criticism, and any student production takes a side in it whether it means to or not.

The canon and the syllabus

The Nigerian dramatic canon was made in the university: the plays taught in the 1970s and 1980s became the plays produced, anthologised and examined. That canon is strong on Soyinka, Rotimi, Osofisan and Clark, and thinner on women, on the popular theatre, on the north and on the languages other than English.

A student should read the canon and then read around it: Zulu Sofola, Tess Onwueme, Bode Sowande, Kole Omotoso, Ahmed Yerima, and the travelling theatre repertoire that the canon left out. The gaps are part of the history.

When you write about a Nigerian play, say which tradition it belongs to and which audience it was written for. A university festival play and a market video drama are not competing on the same terms, and criticism that pretends they are will misread both.

Exercises

1. Compare how Soyinka and Osofisan use a chorus, in one scene from each.
2. Take a Greek tragedy and outline a Nigerian adaptation, naming the setting, the gods and the political stake.
3. Write a review of a post-colonial Nigerian play that takes a position on the myth-versus-politics argument.

Where to read more

Wole Soyinka, Myth, Literature and the African World (1976)

Femi Osofisan, The Nostalgic Drum (2001)

Yemi Ogunbiyi (ed.), Drama and Theatre in Nigeria (1981)

Awam Amkpa, Theatre and Postcolonial Desires (2004)

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